

Cover letter draft

Dear Editor,

Please consider the manuscript “Auditing Intelligent Employee-Performance Prediction Systems Beyond Accuracy: A Traceable XAI Protocol” as a Research Article in *Expert Systems with Applications*.

Accuracy-focused evaluation can produce misleading conclusions about intelligent human-resource prediction systems. The manuscript presents an integrated, traceable audit protocol that connects nested model selection, information availability, ordinal and per-class errors, probability calibration, exact-model explanations, explanation stability and deletion, subgroup and proxy diagnostics, and evidence lineage.

The central result illustrates the practical need for this protocol. Selecting nominal XGBoost by quadratic weighted kappa yielded a QWK of 0.6418 while recall for the highest recorded rating fell to 0.0076. Random Forest also failed to recognize that category despite strong aggregate ordinal scores. The study therefore shows why deployment-oriented evaluation cannot rely on a single aggregate criterion.

The manuscript fits the journal's focus on testing and managing intelligent systems and its stated application areas of human-resources management and human capital. Its contribution is a practical evaluation protocol rather than a claim of a new learning algorithm. The paper also reports information-policy sensitivity, metric-specific calibration evidence, explanation tests, support-aware subgroup diagnostics, and a partial cross-dataset protocol replication, with explicit limits on causal, fairness, prospective, and deployment interpretations.

[AUTHOR CONFIRMATION REQUIRED: originality, absence of concurrent consideration, approval by all authors, authorship, ethics and consent determinations, competing interests, funding, data availability, and the complete generative-AI declaration.]

Sincerely,

[CORRESPONDING AUTHOR TO CONFIRM]